

Children's inferences about social groups from skewed samples

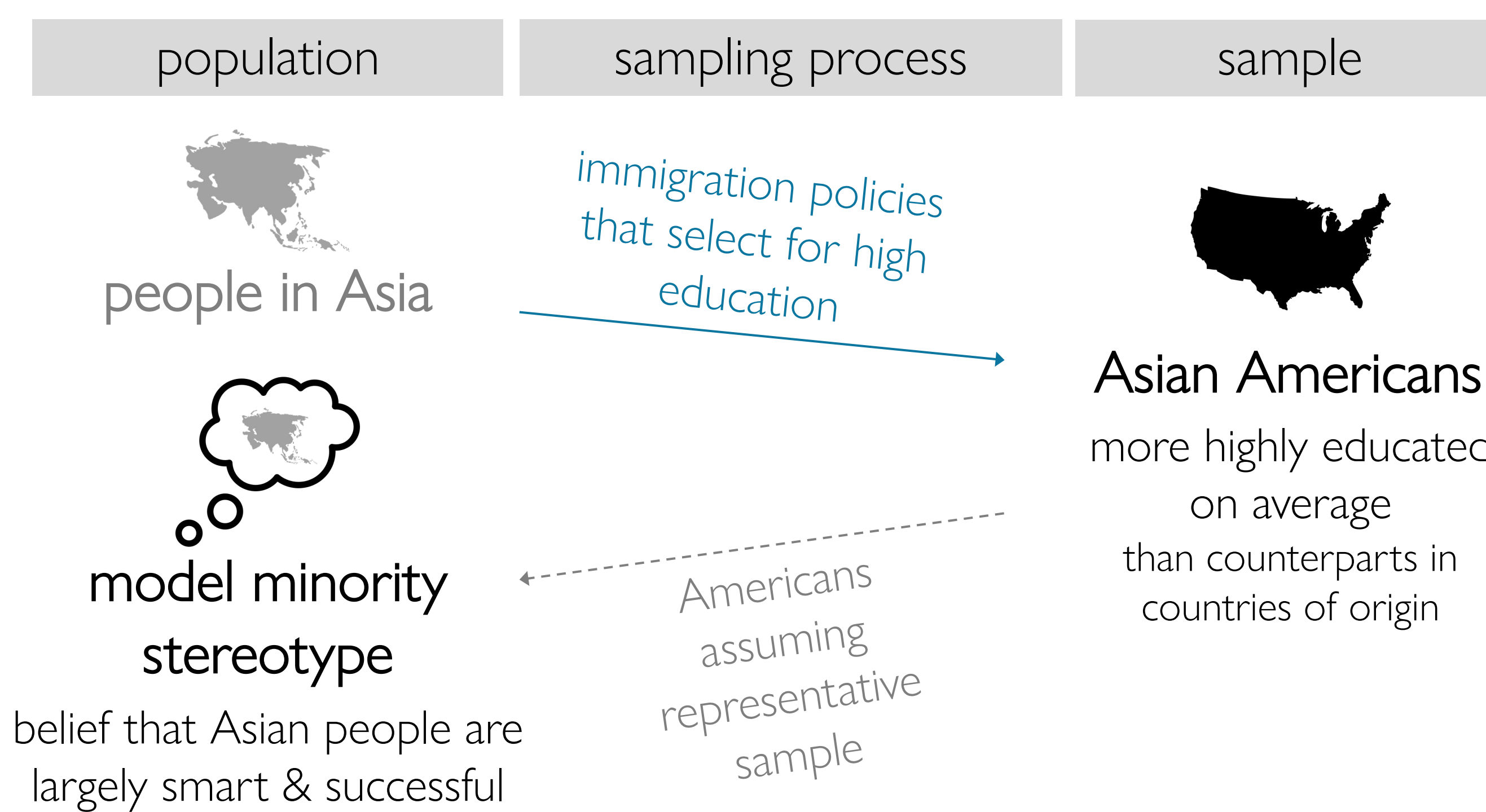
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github.com/mariannazhang/
structural-skew

Children often see **non-representative** members of social groups due to **selective social processes**.

Direct generalization from skewed samples could lead to **stereotypes**.



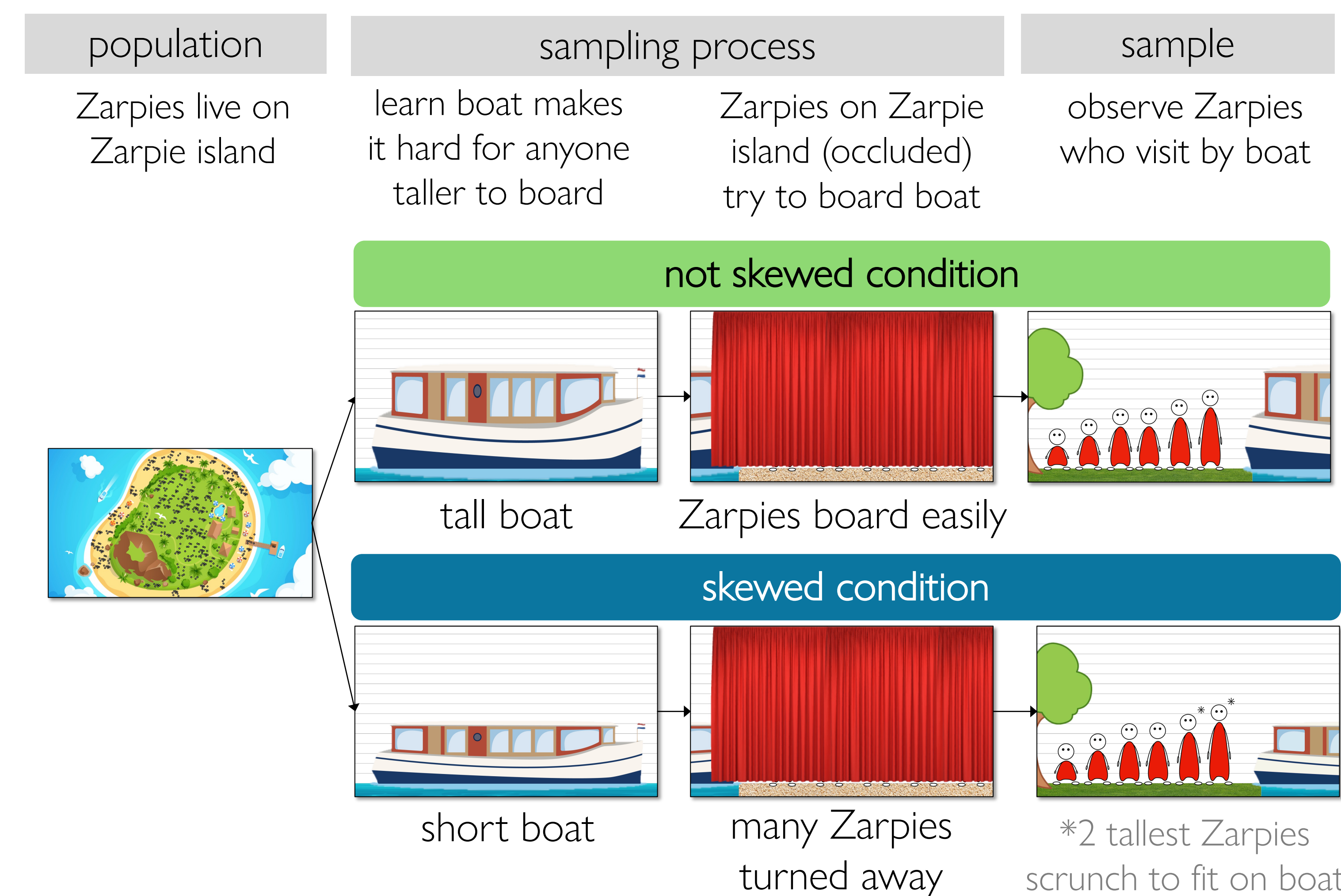
Do children adjust their inferences about social groups to account for selective sampling processes?

The ability to adjust could present a potential lever against stereotypes, and could:

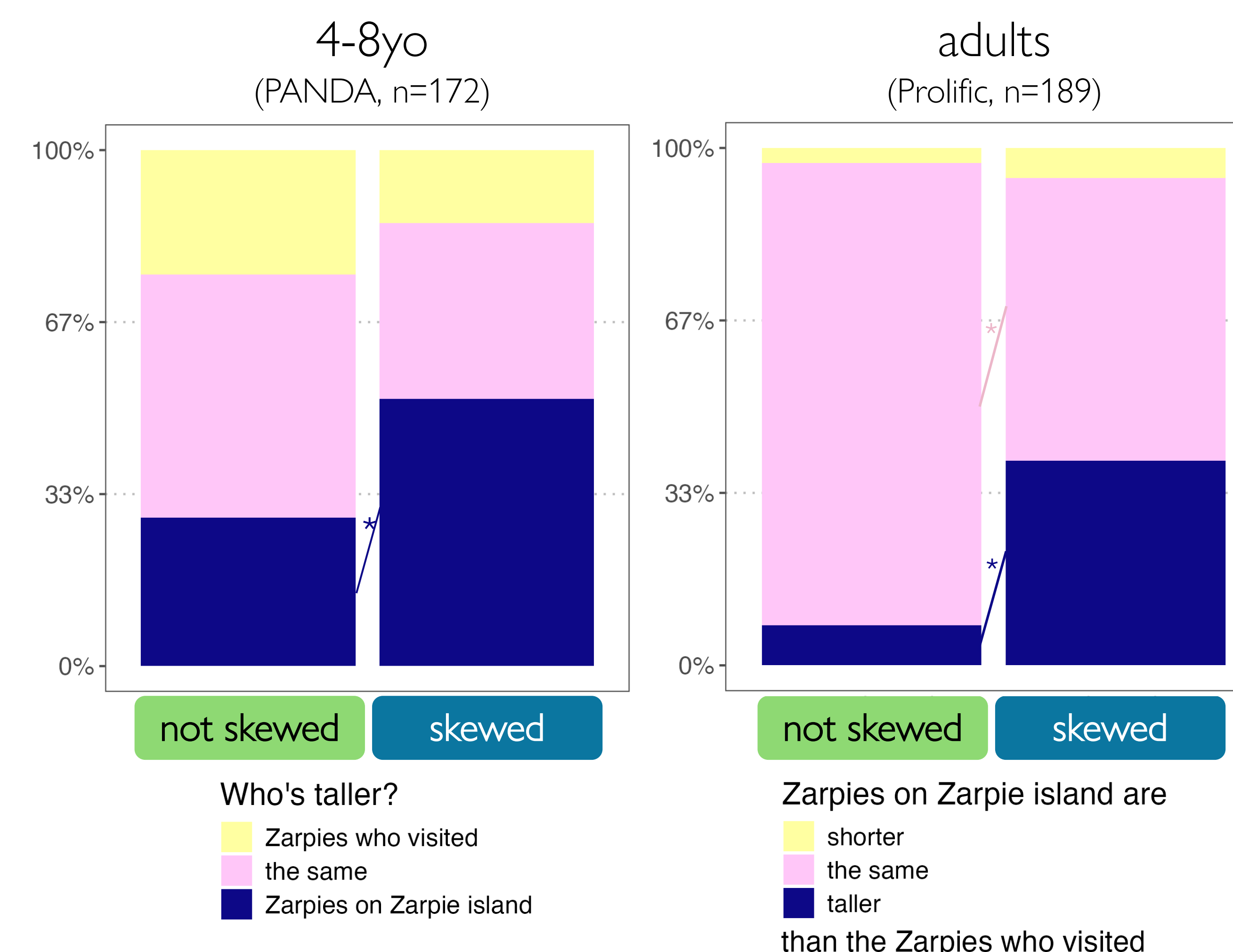
- **emerge early**, as part of domain-general statistical/Bayesian reasoning
11mo generalize from random samples to populations, but don't generalize from intentionally selected samples. (Xu & Denison, 2009)
15mo generalize more widely from random samples, compared to intentionally selected samples. (Gweon et al, 2010)
- **emerge late**, requiring socially-specific structural/constraint-based reasoning
Only starting 5-6yo do children attribute behavioral patterns of social groups to external processes (Vasilyeva et al., 2018), and withhold preference attributions if an agent reaches for the only object in reach (Pesowski et al., 2016).

Exp 1

Do children and adults adjust their inferences about a novel group to account for a selected sample?

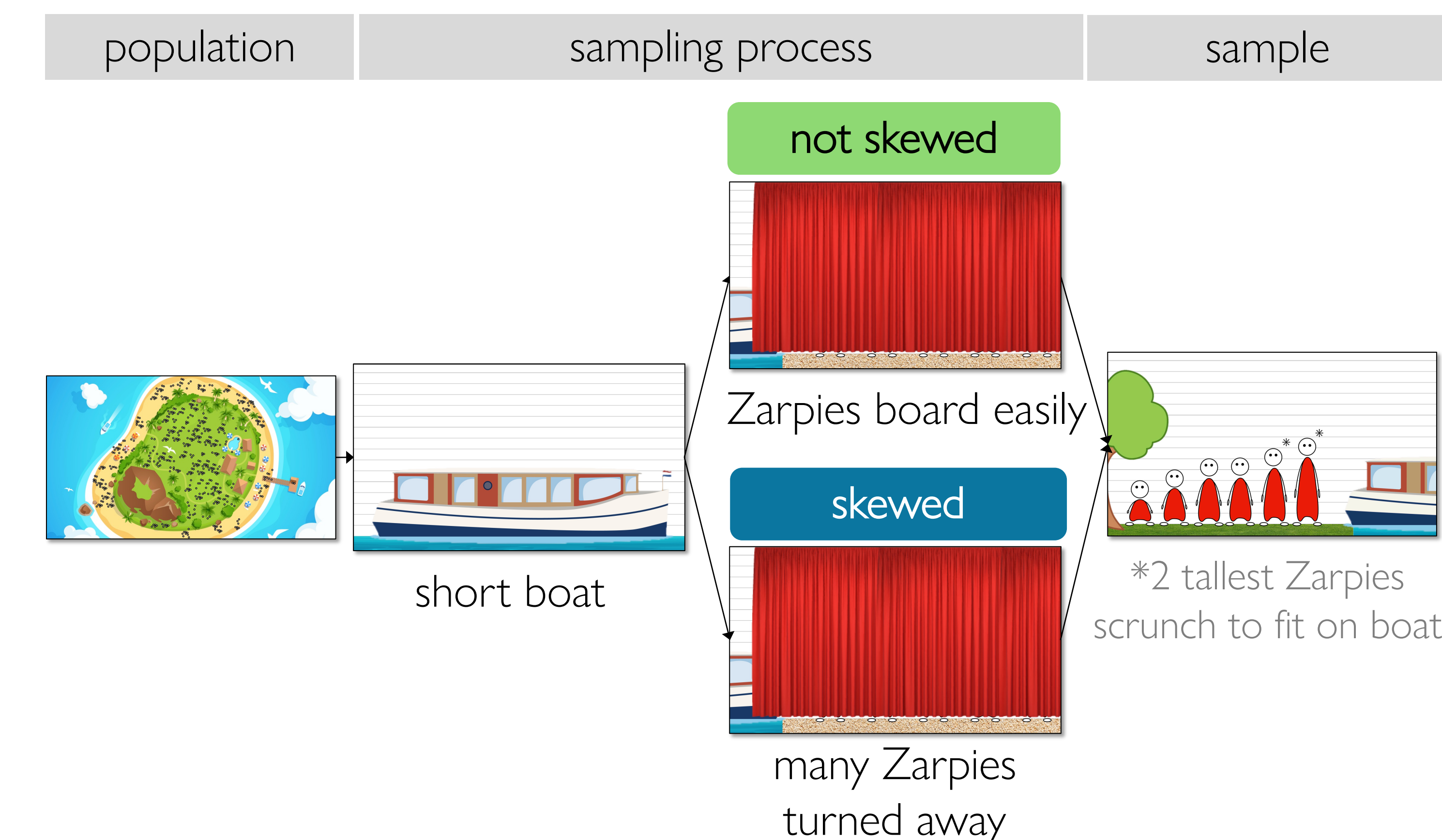


4-8yo & adults inferred that a social group was generally **taller** after observing a sample selected for being short.

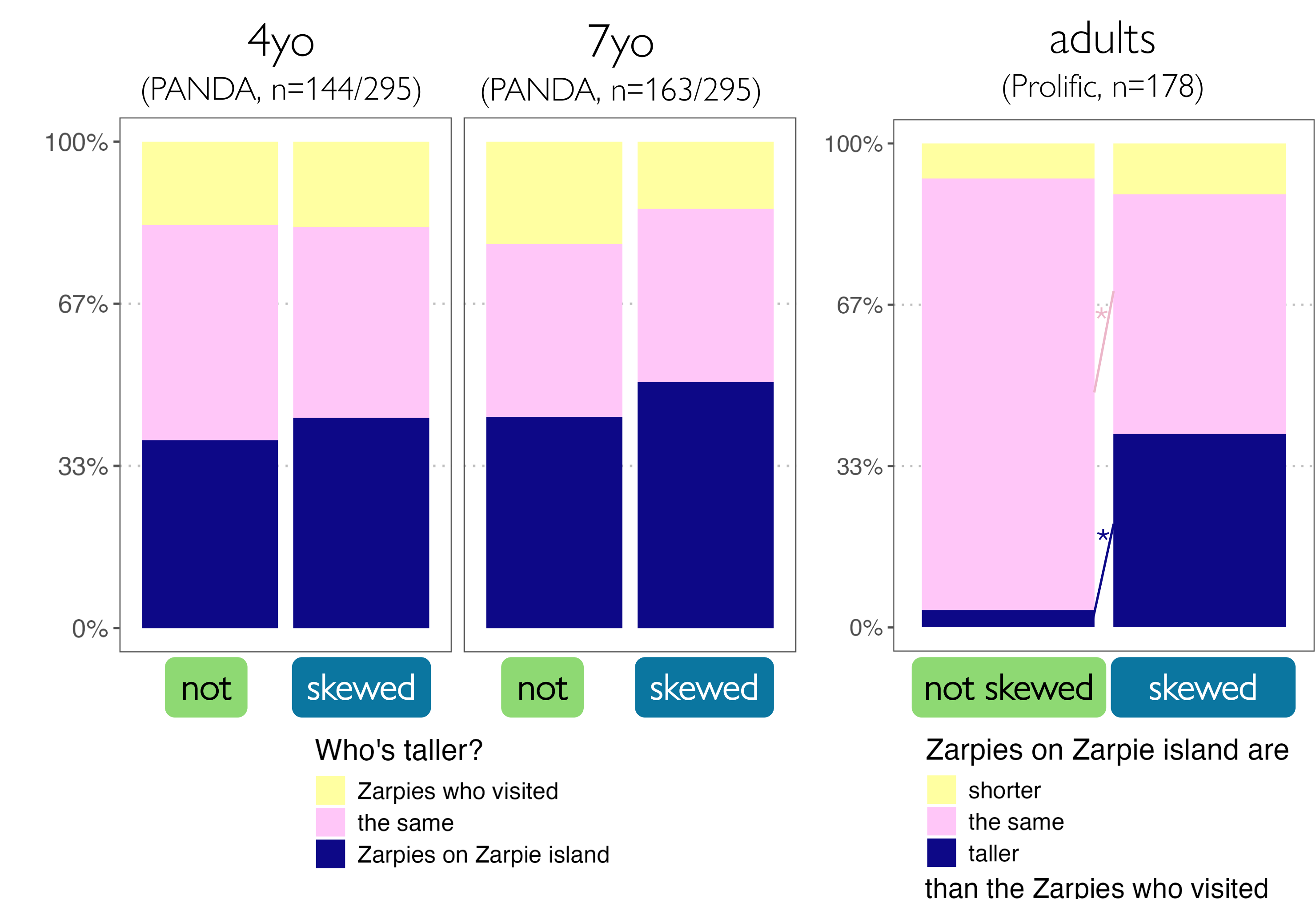


Exp 2

Are there developmental changes?
In Exp 1, rather than adjusting, did participants generalize directly from the sample, weighing the scrunching (=perceptually salient) members more?



But once the sample is perceptually matched, 4yo & 7yo (in progress) may no longer adjust, while adults still do.



Children may struggle to adjust inferences about social groups from skewed samples, paving the way for stereotypes.